

Workplace Readiness Skills — Speaking & Listening

Standard 1.2.1 | Professional Knowledge & Skills

Name: _____ Period: _____ Date: _____

■ STANDARDS CONNECTION

Employers cite poor communication as one of the top reasons new hires struggle. The ability to listen actively, speak clearly, and confirm understanding prevents costly mistakes and is one of the most valued professional skills across every industry.

What Is Speaking & Listening?

Effective workplace communication is not just about talking — it is about ensuring that information travels accurately in both directions. Active listening means fully concentrating on the speaker, not planning your response while they are still talking. Speaking professionally means choosing the right words, tone, and channel for your message.

Skill	What it looks like at work
Active listening	Eye contact, nodding, paraphrasing back: "So what you're saying is..."
Confirming understanding	"Just to confirm — you want X done by Y time, correct?"
Appropriate tone	Adjusting your formality to the audience — supervisor vs. peer vs. client.
Nonverbal communication	Posture, eye contact, facial expression — often louder than words.
Choosing the right channel	Knowing when to call vs. email vs. speak in person.

Part 1 — Ranking Activity

Your supervisor gives you a complex verbal instruction. Below are 6 possible responses. **Rank them from 1 (most professional and effective) to 6 (least).** Write your rank in the left column. Then justify your #1 and #6 choices below. **Circle the one response you find most debatable.**

Rank	Employee Behavior
_____	Nod and walk away to start the task immediately.
_____	Say "Got it" — then ask a coworker what they heard.
_____	Restate the key steps back to the supervisor and ask: "Is that correct?"

Rank	Employee Behavior
_____	Write down what you remember immediately after and do your best.
_____	Say: "I'm not sure I caught everything — could you walk me through the main steps once more?"
_____	Wait to see if you make a mistake before asking for clarification.

Why did you rank #1 highest?

Why did you rank #6 lowest?

Part 2 — Scenario Questions

Respond in **complete sentences**. Support your position with reasoning.

SCENARIO 1

A supervisor gives Marcus a complex verbal instruction covering six steps for a new procedure. Marcus nods along confidently, but when he begins the task he realizes he only retained about half the information and makes two significant errors.

Who is responsible for this communication breakdown — Marcus, the supervisor, or both? What should Marcus have done differently? What should the supervisor have done differently? Is it ever weak or embarrassing to ask for clarification?

SCENARIO 2

A coworker always interrupts people mid-sentence during meetings, finishes others' thoughts, and immediately jumps to solutions before everyone has finished sharing the problem. Her ideas are usually good.

Is her communication style a problem, and if so, why? Can someone be a strong communicator while being a poor listener? What is the professional impact of her behavior on the team?

SCENARIO 3

Devon works at a hospital reception desk. A patient's family member approaches visibly upset and speaking very fast. Devon can only understand about half of what they are saying.

What should Devon do first, second, and third? What should Devon absolutely avoid doing? How does nonverbal communication matter here? Write your response as a step-by-step plan.

SCENARIO 4

A student argues: "I communicate fine with my friends and family — I don't need to change how I talk just because I'm at work. People should accept me as I am."

Do you agree or disagree? Is there a difference between authentic communication and professional communication? What would you tell this person about how workplace communication works?

SCENARIO 5

You are presenting to a group and someone asks a long, complicated question that you are not entirely sure you understood correctly.

Walk through exactly what you would do and say — step by step. Why is it important to confirm your understanding before answering? What is the risk of just guessing at what they meant?

■ PEER COMPARISON

Find a classmate and compare your answer to Scenario 1. Write **one thing that was different** about how you each responded — and explain which response you think is stronger and why.

■ **RESEARCH EXTENSION** (if time allows)

Search "active listening techniques workplace" and find one specific technique you had not considered before.

Write 3 sentences: what the technique is, why it works, and how you could apply it in your career pathway. **OR** — describe a real situation where a communication failure caused a real problem. What happened and what should have been done differently?

➤ EXIT TICKET — detach and hand to your teacher on the way out

Exit Ticket — Standard 1.2.1: Speaking & Listening

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REFLECT & RESPOND

Describe one specific speaking or listening habit you want to improve before you enter the workforce. Explain what the professional consequence could be if you do not improve it, and name one concrete step you will take to work on it. Write at least 3 complete sentences.

This standard is assessed on the Nevada WRS exam. Your honest, thoughtful reflection here helps you think like a professional — which is exactly what the exam tests.